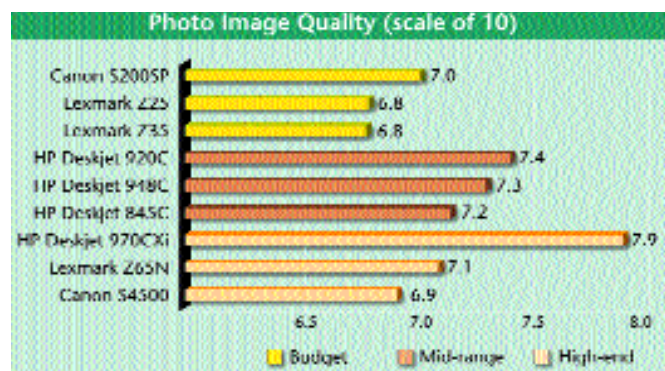




with new cartridges. The entire Epson series failed to register a decent score of over 6—the best score logged by an Epson printer was by the Stylus 895, a mediocre 5.2.

Overall quality (combi document): The combination document (see Test process) is probably the best way to judge a printer's true quality for ordinary day-to-day printing. It includes text in different point sizes, photos, vector graphics and a varying colour palette across the sheet. The resolution test is probably the most critical component of this test. This was tested through the image of the different coloured converging lines placed within a circle.

In the budget category, both the Canon printers, the S200SP and the BJC-2100SP, were the best when it came to printing vector graphics. They scored a decent 3.1 and 2.7 respectively in the resolution test. In the colour bar test, only the Olivetti Artjet 12 could print seven distinctly visible colour bars. The Canon S200SP could manage only six and the rest were at five or less.

The small photo test was another area where the Olivetti Artjet 12 did well. It printed both the photos with a high level of detail.

Reproducing text on black background was probably the toughest test for these budget printers. There were 13 lines of text on a black patch. The best score here was logged by the Lexmark Z25—it showed 11 distinctly readable lines of text. However, some could manage only three lines and the Canon BJC-2100SP and the Lexmark Z13 could not manage more than four lines. The Olivetti Artjet 12 scored 9, which is pretty average. In fact, the printer did well in all of the combi document tests and is a good choice if you print a lot of Web-based content or print graphics, tables and text.

In the mid-range segment only the HP Deskjet 920C, 948C and the Olivetti Artjet 22 scored over 3 points in the resolution test, with the 920C scoring the maximum at 3.4 points.

In the colour bar test both the Olivetti Artjet 22 and the HP Deskjet 920C scored 7 points each. A printer that can show seven or more distinct colour bars is excellent and if you need printouts with a lot of shades of colour, then these two printers are good choices.

As in the budget segment, the entry from Olivetti performed brilliantly in printing the two small photos. The Artjet 22 scored 3.5 and 4.2 respectively for the two photos. The HP Deskjet 920C also managed a very respectable 3.4 and 3.8, respectively.

In the text readability test, the HP Deskjet 920C edged out the Artjet 22 by a slender margin, scoring 4.3 as against the 4 points scored by the latter. The highest scorer for printing the yellow text on black background was logged by the Sharp AJ-1100—it was able to reproduce 10 of the 13 lines of text. This is quite surprising considering its otherwise dismal performance in the combi document

test—it scored only 2 out of 5 in the resolution test and we could see only five colour bars with distinctly separate shades. It scored below average in both the small photo tests too.

The combi document resolution test again proved to be quite a stumbling block for many of the big boys in the high-end segment. Not many could score over 2 except for the Epson Stylus 895—the circle was perfectly drawn with the lines inside ending exactly where they were supposed to, giving it a very impressive score of 4.3 in the resolution test.

In the small photo test, the HP Deskjet 970CXi showed unmatched quality. The level of detail was astounding and it scored a generous 3.1 and 4.6 for the two photos. The Epson Stylus 895 too did well and scored 3.3 and 4.1 for the two photos.

The HP printers performed well in both the colour bar and yellow text rendering tests. We could make out eight distinct colour bars in both, the 1125C and the 970CXi, with the 970CXi also showing an impressive 10 lines of distinctly readable text.

The HP Deskjet 970CXi and the Epson Stylus 895 were the best printers in the combi document section, scoring consistently well in all the tests.

Cost of ownership

The cost of cartridges coupled with the printing capacity of the cartridges play a very important role in the overall long-term viability of the inkjet you buy. Hence, for the first time ever we included a cartridge drain test. This test is designed to calculate the life of a cartridge and the actual cost-per-page of the printer.

The combined (black and colour) average cost per page for these printers ideally should not exceed Rs 4. To achieve this figure, manufacturers have a tough job at hand—they need to keep the cartridge prices low and at the same time increase the number of pages you can print per cartridge.

As far as budget printers go, Canon's strategy is to keep cartridge costs at a bare minimum, but it does so by compromising on page counts. So even though the Canon S200SP can print only 99 black pages and 153 colour pages, the cost of replacing the cartridge is as low as Rs 395 for black and Rs 695 for colour. The cost per page for this printer turns out to be a decent Rs 4.2.

The Canon BJC-2100SP, on the other hand, scores a trifle better. It prints only 79 black pages and 146 colour pages, but the cartridge cost is an amazingly low Rs 345 for black and Rs 395 for colour. This brings down the cost per page to a neat Rs 3.73.

HP's strategy is to ensure that the cartridge is voluminous and can print higher page counts. The HP Deskjet 656C prints a whopping 346 pages in black and 378 (the highest recorded in the test) for colour. The cost of the cartridges is Rs 1,150 for the

